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Assignment 201

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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Full Legal Name: Su Wati

Institution: Institute of International Professionalism (IIP International School)

Category: Junior

Class/Grade/Year: O Level

Country: Myanmar (Formerly Burma)

Major (if senior):

Submission Date: September 19, 2026

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Research Topic: Judgment for Communication: Investigating How Perceived Linguistic Difference Shapes Social and Educational Opportunities for Ethnic Minority Youth in Myanmar

Key Words: Social and linguistic bias in Myanmar, ethnic minorities, social sciences and humanities

Research Topic: Judgment for Communication: Investigating How Perceived Linguistic Difference Shapes Social and Educational Opportunities for Ethnic Minority Youth in Myanmar

Research Problem:

Located in Southeast Asia, Myanmar (formerly Burma) is geographically composed of seven states and seven regions. Myanmar is home to over 135 ethnic groups and more than 100 languages, making it a country rich in cultural and linguistic diversity [1]. This diversity is reflected not only in the languages spoken across the country, but also in the ways people communicate, identify themselves, and interact with one another. However, when particular accents or dialects become associated with certain ethnic, geographical, or social groups, speakers may be judged based on their linguistic characteristics rather than their individual abilities. These judgments may influence perceptions of academic competence, leadership ability, trustworthiness, and social compatibility [2].

Existing research has examined language barriers and inequalities within Myanmar's education system, but less is known about how perceived linguistic differences influence young people's judgments of others in social and educational settings and, in turn, the opportunities offered to them in educational or social contexts [3]. This research aims to investigate whether perceived linguistic differences influence how ethnic minority youth in Myanmar are evaluated. Specifically, it will examine whether differences in accent or dialect affect perceptions of academic ability, leadership potential, social compatibility, and access to opportunities.

Research Question:

To what extent does perceived linguistic difference influence young people's perceptions of ethnic minority youth in Myanmar?

1. How do young people perceive accents and dialects associated with different ethnic and regional groups in Myanmar?
2. To what extent does perceived linguistic difference influence judgments of academic ability, leadership potential, and social compatibility?
3. To what extent does perceived linguistic difference influence judgments of a student's suitability for educational opportunities, such as scholarships or admission to prestigious schools?
4. What factors contribute to positive or negative perceptions of particular accents or dialects?
5. Are young people aware that their judgment of others is being influenced by these factors?

Hypothesis:

Participants will rate students associated with a perceived ethnic minority linguistic background more positively than from students associated with a dominant linguistic background, despite identical characteristics on other fronts.

Literature Review:

Language variation is not only the way an individual speaks; it is also a reflection of historical, geographical, and familial influences that shape how someone communicates [4]. Myanmar provides a useful context for examining linguistic variety, which has also been recognized in the country's legislation. Article 21 of the Constitution of the Union of Burma (1974) stipulated that all national races had the right to develop their languages, provided that exercising this right did not conflict with the public interest [5]. Nevertheless, cultural assimilation has weakened the visibility of non-dominant ethnic cultures through educational instruction, materials, and teacher training centered largely on Bamar culture [6].

Although efforts have been made to integrate ethnic languages and cultures into the mainstream curriculum, many ethnic identities remain underrepresented in formal education. Following education reforms after 2010, ethnic languages were gradually reintroduced into government schools. However, from 2012, they were generally taught outside regular school hours, while Burmese remained the dominant language of formal education. As a result, many ethnic minority communities continued to rely on non-state education providers, such as community centers and cultural organizations, to teach their languages. This difference in language use has also affected students' educational experiences [7].

Sociolinguistics is the scientific study of how society and social factors shape language use. In this context, it is possible to trace someone's roots through the dialect they use. Certain accents may also be associated with particular levels of education or social class, leading speakers to be perceived as more or less educated, credible, or socially competent based on their way of speaking rather than their actual abilities [8]. This can lead to negative professional, educational, and social outcomes [9].

Existing research examines how successive central governments in Myanmar have historically suppressed other ethnic languages in favor of promoting Burmese as a tool for cultural assimilation and political centralization. Less research focuses specifically on how perceived accents and dialects influence young people's judgments, primarily in educational and social settings, of ethnic minority individuals in Myanmar. In particular, there is limited research on whether linguistic differences affect perceptions of academic ability, leadership potential, social compatibility, and suitability for educational opportunities among peers [10].

This gap provides a basis for investigating how linguistic perceptions may shape the social and educational experiences of ethnic minority youth in Myanmar.

Methodology:

This study will adopt a mixed-methods approach to provide a comprehensive understanding of how perceived linguistic difference influences young people's perceptions of ethnic minority youth in Myanmar.

Quantitative Component

- A survey-based quasi-experimental design will be used to examine whether perceived linguistic differences influence participants' evaluations of hypothetical students.
- Participants will be presented with otherwise similar student profiles that vary in their perceived linguistic background or accent.
- Participants will listen to audio recordings of a speech delivered by different student speakers. The content, wording, and delivery of the speech will remain consistent, with the speaker being the only variable. Age and gender of the speaker will be kept consistent to avoid bias based on other external factors.
- Participants will rate each profile based on academic ability, leadership potential, social compatibility, trustworthiness, and suitability for educational opportunities such as scholarships or admission to prestigious schools. They will use a Likert scale of 1 to 5, 1 (highly unlikely) to 5(highly likely).
- A sample of approximately 50–100 students will be selected through convenience or voluntary sampling, depending on accessibility.
- Quantitative data will be analyzed by comparing the average ratings assigned to individuals associated with different linguistic backgrounds.

Qualitative Component

- Open-ended survey questions will be included to explore the reasons behind participants' evaluations and their perceptions of different accents and dialects.
- Responses will be analyzed thematically to identify recurring factors influencing participants' judgments, such as perceived education, social class, ethnicity, familiarity, or communication ability.

Secondary Research

- Academic articles, reports, historical documents, and educational research will be examined to provide background on Myanmar's linguistic diversity, language policy, ethnic minority languages, and linguistic discrimination.
- Findings from secondary sources will be compared with the primary data to identify similarities, differences, and possible explanations for the observed patterns.

Ethical Considerations

- Participation will be voluntary, and informed consent will be obtained from all participants and guardians in the case of minors.
- The survey will be anonymous, and no personally identifying information will be collected.
- Participants will be informed of the purpose of the study to the extent that may not evoke bias and may withdraw from participation at any time.
- Care will be taken to avoid reinforcing stereotypes or presenting any ethnic or linguistic group as inherently associated with particular abilities or characteristics.

- All collected data will be kept confidential and used solely for the purposes of this research.

Independent variable: the accent or the linguistic background of the speaker
Dependent variable: the perception of students regarding social, educational, or professional ability

Limitations:

- The sample of approximately 50–100 students will be selected through convenience or voluntary sampling, which may limit the spontaneity and generalization of young people across Myanmar.
- Participants may provide socially acceptable responses rather than expressing their genuine opinions, particularly because the research concerns ethnicity, language, and potential discrimination. This may stem from a concern of being seen as a promoter of biased behavior.
- Because different speakers may naturally vary in voice, tone, pronunciation, confidence, and speaking style, it may be difficult to isolate accent or linguistic background as the sole cause of differences in participants' evaluations. Other factors may also affect the results.
- The study will use hypothetical student profiles and audio recordings rather than real-life educational or social decision-making situations. Participants' responses may therefore differ from their behavior in real-world contexts, where there may already be existing biases.
- The research will measure participants' perceptions and evaluations rather than actual educational or social outcomes. Therefore, the findings cannot directly establish that linguistic differences cause individuals to receive fewer opportunities.
- Myanmar's extensive linguistic and ethnic diversity cannot be fully represented within a study of this scale. The findings will therefore be limited to the linguistic backgrounds and accents included in the research.

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